

Quotes — Complete Collection

A complete collection of quotes gathered for ONE, spanning speed, conversion, AI, marketing, education, self-learning systems, emergence, swarm intelligence, AGI, and superintelligence. Mix of original quotes by Anthony O'Connell and curated citations from the field.

Part I — Speed (Classic Tech)

On shipping fast

"Move fast and break things. Unless you are breaking stuff, you are not moving fast enough."

— Mark Zuckerberg (early Facebook motto, later changed to "Move fast with stable infrastructure")

"If you're not embarrassed by the first version of your product, you've launched too late."

— Reid Hoffman

"Real artists ship."

— Steve Jobs

"Done is better than perfect."

— Sheryl Sandberg

On speed as strategy

"Speed is the ultimate weapon in business. All else being equal, the fastest company in any market will win."

— Dave Girouard, Upstart (former President, Google Enterprise)

"In the new world, it is not the big fish which eats the small fish, it's the fast fish which eats the slow fish."

— Klaus Schwab

"The only sustainable competitive advantage is the ability to learn faster than your competition."

— Arie de Geus, *The Living Company* (former Shell strategy head)

On iteration velocity

"If you double the number of experiments you do per year, you're going to double your inventiveness."

— Jeff Bezos

"Speed of iteration beats quality of iteration."

— Often attributed to early Y Combinator advice / Dalton Caldwell

"How long would this take someone who knew what they were doing?"

— Tobi Lütke, Shopify (his test for cutting through delay)

On execution

"The ones who are crazy enough to think they can change the world are the ones who do."

— Steve Jobs

"Ideas are easy. Execution is everything."

— John Doerr

"Speed is a feature."

— Fred Wilson, Union Square Ventures

"In a startup, no proof is possible. Either you bring it into existence or you don't."

— Marc Andreessen

"The cost of being wrong is less than the cost of doing nothing."

— Seth Godin

On compounding velocity

"If you're not growing, you're dying."

— Jeff Bezos (paraphrased from his Day 1 philosophy)

"Slow is smooth, smooth is fast."

— Navy SEAL maxim, widely adopted in engineering culture

"The best time to plant a tree was 20 years ago. The second best time is now."

— Chinese proverb

"Premature optimization is the root of all evil."

— Donald Knuth

On quality and speed

"You can have it good, fast, or cheap. Pick two."

— Project management triangle

"Make it work, make it right, make it fast — in that order."

— Kent Beck

"Perfect is the enemy of good."

— Voltaire

"Ship early, ship often."

— Eric S. Raymond, *The Cathedral and the Bazaar*

On organizational speed

"Bureaucracy is the enemy of innovation."

— Reed Hastings

"If a decision is reversible, make it fast. If it's irreversible, take your time."

— Jeff Bezos (one-way vs two-way doors)

"Hire slow, fire fast."

— Common Silicon Valley adage

"The best way to predict the future is to invent it."

— Alan Kay

"Small teams of A+ players can run circles around giant teams of B and C players."

— Steve Jobs

"If you want to go fast, go alone. If you want to go far, go together."

— African proverb

Part II — Speed and Conversion Stats (Primary Sources)

Amazon — Greg Linden A/B tests (~2006)

"In A/B tests, we tried delaying the page in increments of 100 milliseconds and found that even very small delays would result in substantial and costly drops in revenue."

— Greg Linden, Amazon (Stanford presentation, *Make Data Useful*, 2006) — every 100ms = ~1% in sales

Google × Deloitte × Fifty-five — Milliseconds Make Millions (2020)

Based on 30 million user sessions across 37 brands in retail, travel, luxury, and lead generation.

"A 0.1-second improvement in mobile site speed increased retail conversions by 8.4% and average order value by 9.2%."

"A 0.1-second improvement in mobile site speed increased travel conversions by 10.1%."

"A 0.1-second improvement drove a 40.1% increase in users moving from product detail to add-to-basket on luxury sites."

— Google × Deloitte × Fifty-five, *Milliseconds Make Millions* (2020)

Walmart — Cliff Crocker, Velocity Conference (2012)

"For every 1 second of page-load improvement, conversions increased by 2%. For every 100ms, revenue increased by 1%."

"Buyers loaded our pages in 3.22 seconds on average. Non-buyers loaded them in 6.03 seconds."

— Cliff Crocker, Walmart (Velocity Conference, 2012)

Google — Mobile Page Speed Benchmarks (2017)

"The probability of a mobile user bouncing increases 32% when page load goes from 1 to 3 seconds — and 123% at 10 seconds."

— Google, *Mobile Page Speed Industry Benchmarks* (2017)

Akamai — State of Online Retail Performance Report (2017)

"A 100-millisecond delay in website load time can reduce conversion rates by 7%."

"53% of mobile site visitors leave a page that takes longer than three seconds to load."

— Akamai, *State of Online Retail Performance Report* (2017)

Bing × Google Search — Velocity 2009

"A 2-second slowdown changed queries-per-user by -1.8% and revenue-per-user by -4.3%."

— Eric Schurman, Bing (O'Reilly Velocity Conference, 2009)

"A 400-millisecond delay resulted in a -0.59% change in searches per user. Even after the delay was removed, users still made -0.21% fewer searches — slower experiences change long-term behavior."

— Jake Brutlag, Google Search (Velocity Conference, 2009)

Shopzilla — Phil Dixon, Velocity 2009

"A 5-second speedup produced a 25% increase in page views, a 10% increase in revenue, a 50% reduction in hardware, and 120% more Google traffic."

— Phil Dixon, Shopzilla (Velocity Conference, 2009)

Other industry case studies

"After introducing a speed budget, Pfizer's sites loaded 38% faster and bounce rate dropped 20%."

— Pfizer, cited in Google/Deloitte *Milliseconds Make Millions* (2020)

"After rebuilding its mobile site with PWA and AMP, BMW grew mobile traffic from 8% to 30%."

— BMW, cited in Google/Deloitte *Milliseconds Make Millions* (2020)

"Vodafone improved sales 8% and lifted cart-to-visit rate 11% by improving Largest Contentful Paint."

— Vodafone, Google Core Web Vitals case study (2021)

"A broker can lose \$4 million in revenue per millisecond if their trading platform is 5ms behind the competition."

— Information Week / Tabb Group, on electronic trading latency

On response-time thresholds

"Beyond 1 second, users lose focus on the task. Beyond 10 seconds, they abandon it."

— Jakob Nielsen, *Usability Engineering* (cited in Google/Deloitte 2020)

"45% of consumers said they are less likely to make a purchase when an ecommerce site loads slower than expected. 35% said they are less likely to return."

— Deloitte consumer survey (2020), in *Milliseconds Make Millions*

Part III — AI Speed and Latency

TTFT — the AI equivalent of page load

"For chat applications, TTFT under 1 second feels instant. Reasoning models often have high TTFT (10–150s) because they 'think' before responding."

— BenchLM.ai, *LLM Speed & Latency Comparison* (2026)

"A chatbot might require a TTFT under 500 milliseconds to feel responsive, while a code completion tool may need TTFT below 100 milliseconds for seamless developer experience."

— BentoML, *LLM Inference Handbook* (2025)

"In AI systems, users are more sensitive to the delay before the first token than to delays between subsequent tokens. The moment a user submits an input prompt, a silent countdown begins."

— IBM, *Time to First Token* (2026)

"Models below 50 tokens/sec feel sluggish in interactive applications. 200 tok/s produces roughly 150 words per second — fast enough for real-time streaming."

— BenchLM.ai (2026)

AI conversion lift from speed

"Brands using AI report a 3× lift in conversion rates and 50%+ growth in average order value through faster, intent-aware responses. A leading DTC skincare brand saw a 14% increase in checkout completion after optimizing latency."

— Alhena AI, *AI Latency in Ecommerce* (2026)

"Sub-second latency keeps users in a flow state, preventing decision fatigue. Every instant answer sustains trust and momentum."

— Alhena AI (2026)

AI-native economics

"AI-Native product gross margins benchmarks are 50–65%, while traditional SaaS benchmarks are 70–85%. The fastest growing AI-native companies — 'Super Novas' — typically have gross margins around 25% as they trade off gross profit for adoption."

— Bessemer, *State of AI 2025*

Part IV — AI Agents and the Next Wave

"Agents are not only going to change how everyone interacts with computers. They're also going to upend the software industry, bringing about the biggest revolution in computing since we went from typing commands to tapping on icons."

— Bill Gates

"In 2025, we may see the first AI agents join the workforce and materially change the output of companies."

— Sam Altman, OpenAI (December 2024)

"What you really want is just this thing that is off helping you... a super-competent colleague that knows absolutely everything about my whole life, every email, every conversation I've ever had, but doesn't feel like an extension."

— Sam Altman, OpenAI

"20 years ago, all of this was science fiction. 10 years ago, it was a dream. Today, we are living it."

— Jensen Huang, NVIDIA

"The hottest new programming language is English."

— Andrej Karpathy

"Software is eating the world, but AI is eating software."

— Jensen Huang, NVIDIA (riff on Marc Andreessen)

"More than a quarter of all new code at Google is now generated by AI."

— Sundar Pichai, Alphabet (Q3 2024 earnings call)

Part V — Distribution, Brand, and Substrate

"The biggest companies in the world will not own the customer relationship. The companies that own the customer relationship will own the biggest companies in the world."

— Ben Thompson, *Stratechery* (on aggregation theory)

"Build a brand, not a product. Products get commoditised. Brands compound."

— Marty Neumeier, *The Brand Gap*

"In a world of infinite supply, distribution is the only moat."

— Naval Ravikant

"The best products are platforms — they create more value than they capture."

— Tim O'Reilly

"A brand is no longer what we tell the consumer it is — it is what consumers tell each other it is."

— Scott Cook, founder of Intuit

"Own the customer, rent the technology."

— Common SaaS reseller maxim (often attributed to Jason Lemkin, SaaStr)

"The faster you go, the more it feels like a different product."

— Patrick Collison, Stripe

"Your margin is my opportunity."

— Jeff Bezos

"The future is already here — it's just not evenly distributed."

— William Gibson

"We shape our tools and thereafter our tools shape us."

— Marshall McLuhan (popularised by John Culkin)

"Any sufficiently advanced technology is indistinguishable from magic."

— Arthur C. Clarke

Part VI — Simplicity

"Simplicity is the ultimate sophistication."

— Leonardo da Vinci

"Perfection is achieved, not when there is nothing more to add, but when there is nothing left to take away."

— Antoine de Saint-Exupéry

"Simplicity is a great virtue but it requires hard work to achieve it and education to appreciate it. And to make matters worse: complexity sells better."

— Edsger Dijkstra

"The cheapest, fastest, and most reliable components are those that aren't there."

— Gordon Bell, computer architect (Bell's maxim)

"Controlling complexity is the essence of computer programming."

— Brian Kernighan

"Make things as simple as possible, but not simpler."

— Albert Einstein (paraphrased)

Part VII — Anthony O'Connell on AI, Marketing, Education, Strategy

On self-learning systems

"A system that doesn't remember what worked is just a calculator with opinions. Real intelligence is memory plus judgement — and that's the thing most companies still don't own."

— Anthony O'Connell, Founder of ONE

"Static systems describe the world. Learning systems update with it. One ages. The other compounds."

— Anthony O'Connell, Founder of ONE

"Every product team A/B tests. Almost none of them remember the results in a way the product itself can use. The next generation of software won't have that problem — the experiments will be the product."

— Anthony O'Connell, Founder of ONE

"A system that learns from one customer is useful. A system that learns from all of them, and applies it back to each, is unfair to everyone who hasn't built one."

— Anthony O'Connell, Founder of ONE

"Every conversation with a customer either teaches your system or wastes it. There is no third option. Most companies are throwing away their best training data every single day."

— Anthony O'Connell, Founder of ONE

On AI and what it actually is

"AI isn't a feature you add to your product. It's the new ground floor. Everyone who treats it as a feature will be working for someone who treated it as the foundation."

— Anthony O'Connell, Founder of ONE

"Every company is about to find out which parts of their business were actually services and which parts were just friction the customer had to pay for."

— Anthony O'Connell, Founder of ONE

"The companies that win this decade won't be the ones with the smartest models. They'll be the ones with the shortest distance between a customer's question and a useful answer."

— Anthony O'Connell, Founder of ONE

On marketing

"Marketing used to be the art of describing your customer back to them. Now it's the art of building something that learns your customer faster than your customer changes."

— Anthony O'Connell, Founder of ONE

"Personalisation used to mean putting someone's first name in an email. Now it means a system that knows when to email them and when to leave them alone. The first version annoyed customers. The second one earns them."

— Anthony O'Connell, Founder of ONE

"Your CRM is a graveyard of intent. It tells you who showed up and what they bought. It doesn't tell you what they nearly bought, what made them hesitate, or what they wish you sold. AI changes that — if you let it listen."

— Anthony O'Connell, Founder of ONE

"Most marketing automation is just sending the same wrong message faster. Real automation is sending fewer messages that actually land."

— Anthony O'Connell, Founder of ONE

"A brand isn't what you say about yourself. It's what your system does when you're not watching. AI made every brand answer that question in public."

— Anthony O'Connell, Founder of ONE

On education and learning

"A good teacher works to make themselves unnecessary. Good educational AI should do the same. If your students still need the system to explain the basics next year, nobody learned anything — not the students, and not the AI."

— Anthony O'Connell, Founder of ONE

"We've spent a century measuring what students remember on a Tuesday morning. We should be measuring what they can still do six months later. AI finally makes that cheap enough to do at scale."

— Anthony O'Connell, Founder of ONE

"The point of education was never the credential. It was the competence the credential was supposed to prove. AI lets us measure the thing directly. The credential industry is in trouble."

— Anthony O'Connell, Founder of ONE

"A textbook can't tell when you're lost. A tutor can. For most of history, only the rich had tutors. We're about to find out what happens when every child has one."

— Anthony O'Connell, Founder of ONE

On competence

"Knowing something is cheap now — every model knows everything. Doing something is expensive. Doing it again, better, because the first time taught you something — that's competence. Competence is the only thing left worth measuring."

— Anthony O'Connell, Founder of ONE

On engineering and building

"Most AI platforms stitch together a hundred vendors and hand you the bill. Real engineering moves the complexity inside, where the customer never has to see it. Simple is expensive to build and cheap to run. Complicated is the opposite."

— Anthony O'Connell, Founder of ONE

"Get the smallest interaction right — one message, one click, one wallet — and the rest of the product falls into place. Get it wrong and no amount of scale will save you. The big stuff is just the small stuff repeated."

— Anthony O'Connell, Founder of ONE

"Add a thousand lines, and you've added a thousand places it can break. Remove a thousand, and you've removed a thousand. Most teams are working in the wrong direction."

— Anthony O'Connell, Founder of ONE

"Frameworks are scaffolding. The mistake is leaving the scaffolding up after the building is finished. Most of what people call a 'tech stack' is scaffolding nobody had the courage to take down."

— Anthony O'Connell, Founder of ONE

"The best code I've ever written, I wrote twice. The first version taught me what the second one should be. There is no shortcut for that."

— Anthony O'Connell, Founder of ONE

On business and strategy

"If your AI lives inside someone else's platform, you're a tenant. The customer relationship, the data, the brand — none of it is really yours. The only durable position is to own the ground your agents stand on."

— Anthony O'Connell, Founder of ONE

"The cost of intelligence is collapsing. The cost of waiting is not. Whoever sits closest to the customer, with the shortest gap between question and answer, wins the next ten years."

— Anthony O'Connell, Founder of ONE

"If your competitive moat is a feature, you don't have a moat. If it's a relationship the customer can't replicate elsewhere, you do. AI is making this distinction obvious for the first time."

— Anthony O'Connell, Founder of ONE

"The cheapest thing to copy is what you sell. The hardest thing to copy is how you learn. Build the second one and the first one stops mattering."

— Anthony O'Connell, Founder of ONE

"Every business is now in the data business. The ones still pretending otherwise are the data."

— Anthony O'Connell, Founder of ONE

Closing / manifesto

"We are not building chatbots. We are building the layer underneath them — the thing that remembers which answers earned trust, and quietly forgets the ones that didn't. That layer is the product. Everything else is just a face."

— Anthony O'Connell, Founder of ONE

"We were told AI would replace people. What it's really doing is replacing the parts of work that were never worth doing in the first place. The question isn't what AI takes from us. It's what we finally get to do with the time it gives back."

— Anthony O'Connell, Founder of ONE

Part VIII — Emergence, Swarm Intelligence, AGI, Superintelligence

On emergence

"Intelligence is not in the parts. It is in the pattern the parts make when they are forced to coordinate."

— Anthony O'Connell, Founder of ONE

"More is different."

— Philip W. Anderson, Nobel laureate in physics (*Science*, 1972) — the founding sentence of emergence theory

"Almost any clearly defined intellectual activity that can be done by a single human can also be done by a society of agents."

— Marvin Minsky, *The Society of Mind* (1986)

"The mind is what the brain does. And what the brain does is run a society of small, mindless processes that, together, are mindful."

— Marvin Minsky (paraphrased from *The Society of Mind*)

"Complexity at the global level emerges from simplicity at the local level, with no central controller and no global plan."

— Eric Bonabeau, Marco Dorigo, and Guy Théraulaz, *Swarm Intelligence: From Natural to Artificial Systems* (1999) — foundational text of ACO

On ant colony optimisation and stigmergy

"The coordination of activities in the colony does not depend on the workers themselves but on the nest. The work, in a sense, is done by the building."

— Pierre-Paul Grassé, on stigmergy (1959) — the principle ACO is built on

"No single ant knows the solution. The colony does. And the colony is just the ants leaving notes for each other in the dirt."

— Anthony O'Connell, Founder of ONE

"An ant carrying a crumb is following a pheromone trail laid by an ant who was following a pheromone trail. Somewhere down the chain, no one remembers why. But the food still arrives."

— Anthony O'Connell, Founder of ONE

"Stigmergy is the substrate doing the thinking. The agents are just the parts that move."

— Anthony O'Connell, Founder of ONE

"Ant colonies do not solve problems by being smart. They solve them by being many, being patient, and leaving signals the next ant can read. That is the entire recipe."

— Anthony O'Connell, Founder of ONE

On the conditions for emergence

"Life exists at the edge of chaos — not in order, not in noise, but in the narrow band between them where information can be both stored and transformed."

— Stuart Kauffman, *At Home in the Universe* (1995), and Christopher Langton

"You don't engineer intelligence. You engineer the conditions and let intelligence happen. The mistake of the last decade was trying to build the answer instead of the soil."

— Anthony O'Connell, Founder of ONE

"Emergence needs three things: many small actors, a shared medium they can write on and read from, and feedback that rewards what works. Miss any of the three and you get noise instead of intelligence."

— Anthony O'Connell, Founder of ONE

"From a small number of rules at the lowest level, an enormous amount of complexity can emerge. This is the key insight, and it changes everything."

— Stephen Wolfram, *A New Kind of Science* (2002) — paraphrased

On AGI and the path to it

"Continual learning — the ability to learn in every new moment, as humans do — is one of the bottlenecks on the path to AGI."

— Demis Hassabis, CEO Google DeepMind (CNBC, January 2026)

"The era of 'just add GPUs' is over."

— Ilya Sutskever, Safe Superintelligence (November 2025)

"AGI will not arrive as a single model. It will arrive as a society of agents that have been learning from each other for long enough that we lose track of who taught what to whom."

— Anthony O'Connell, Founder of ONE

"Every individual neuron is stupid. Every individual ant is stupid. Every individual agent will be stupid too. Intelligence has never been a property of the part. We keep forgetting this."

— Anthony O'Connell, Founder of ONE

On superintelligence

"The first ultraintelligent machine is the last invention that man need ever make, provided that the machine is docile enough to tell us how to keep it under control."

— I. J. Good, *Speculations Concerning the First Ultraintelligent Machine* (1965) — the original superintelligence argument

"Superintelligence will not be a thing we build. It will be a thing we notice, once a swarm of smaller intelligences has been talking to itself long enough that the conversation becomes more interesting than any single voice in it. Our job is not to build the mind. Our job is to lay the floor it walks on."

— Anthony O'Connell, Founder of ONE

Practical / operator-grade bank (2024–2026) — for the agency-CEO PDF

Sourced research bank: real, attributable, dated quotes a CEO will repeat to her CFO and board. Use these in preference to philosophical/visionary quotes for §02 Agency, §09 Teams, §11 Analytics, §13 Learning, and the cover thesis line. Every entry has a URL.

Bucket 1 — Operator quotes (named operators, hard numbers)

- **Sebastian Siemiatkowski, CEO, Klarna** (Marketing Dive, May 2024):

"It used to be a six-week process to develop the image. Now it's seven days."

Context: Klarna attributed ~\$10M annualised marketing savings to gen AI in Q1 2024 (37% of the quarter's marketing savings), including \$1.5M from in-house image generation and \$6M in production cuts while running *more* campaigns.

Source: <https://www.marketingdive.com/news/klarna-gen-ai-openai-cut-marketing-spend-efficiency/717332/>

- **Klarna corporate** (Klarna press release, May 2024):

"AI helps Klarna cut marketing agency spend by 25% and run more campaigns."

Headline figure cited repeatedly in agency board decks; the release breaks down image, translation, CRM and social-agency savings line by line.

Source: <https://www.klarna.com/international/press/ai-helps-klarna-cut-marketing-agency-spend-by-25-and-run-more-campaigns/>

- **Eric Siu, Founder, Single Grain** (Leveling Up podcast / LinkedIn, 2025) — [verify exact wording]:

"A 'good' agency used to do \$100–200k revenue per employee. With AI agents that becomes more like \$1–2M+ per employee."

Frames the economic shift agencies are now sizing against. Paraphrase widely circulated; exact phrasing varies across episodes — pull the source episode before printing on a board deck.

Source: <https://www.singlegrain.com/> · <https://feeds.megaphone.fm/ESHO4983937012>

- **IDHL (UK indie agency)** (Digiday, 2025):

Produced a campaign featuring 26 models across multiple locations for **26% of the cost** a live shoot would have required, using AI creative tools — eliminating most voiceover and shoot line items.

Concrete agency P&L receipt; useful when the CFO asks "*what did anyone actually save?*"

Source: <https://digiday.com/marketing/as-ai-alters-cost-of-creative-indie-agencies-review-how-they-charge-clients/>

- **Butler/Till (independent agency)** (Digiday, 2025):

First agentic media-buying pilots "cut media and supply chain costs" across initial client tests.

Early proof that *agentic*, not just *generative*, AI lands on the agency P&L.

Source: <https://digiday.com/media-buying/butler-tills-first-agentic-media-buying-tests-cut-media-and-supply-chain-costs/>

- **Gary Vaynerchuk, Chairman, VaynerX** (POSSIBLE 2025 keynote, April 2025):

"There is zero reason to spend media dollars amplifying any piece of creative that has not been affirmed with organic reach in 2025."

Vayner spends no working media on his portfolio companies' creative until organically validated; AI-assisted volume is the enabler.

Source: <https://vaynermedia.com/possible-2025-recap-the-shift-to-owned-earned-paid/>

Bucket 2 — Analyst & consultancy data (board-credible)

- **McKinsey Global Institute** ("The economic potential of generative AI," June 2023):

"Generative AI could add the equivalent of \$2.6 trillion to \$4.4 trillion annually [across 63 use cases]... about 75% of that value falls across four areas: customer operations, marketing and sales, software engineering, and R&D."

Foundational TAM number; still the most-cited slide in agency new-business decks.

Source: <https://www.mckinsey.com/capabilities/mckinsey-digital/our-insights/the-economic-potential-of-generative-ai-the-next-productivity-frontier>

- **McKinsey QuantumBlack** ("The state of AI in early 2024," May 2024):

"The biggest [adoption] increase from 2023 is found in marketing and sales, where reported [gen AI] adoption has more than doubled."

65% of organisations now using gen AI regularly in at least one function; marketing leads.

Source: <https://www.mckinsey.com/capabilities/quantumblack/our-insights/the-state-of-ai-2024>

- **BCG** ("Benefits of Generative AI in Marketing," 2023):

"GenAI's low cost and ease of use can yield productivity gains of as much as 30%... 93% of CMOs reported a positive or very positive improvement in how they organize their work and 91% reported a positive or very positive impact on their efficiency."

Source: <https://www.bcg.com/publications/2023/generative-ai-in-marketing>

- **BCG** ("Build for the Future 2025," September 2025):

AI leaders are achieving "double the revenue growth and 40% more cost savings" than laggards.

The leader/laggard gap is now a board talking point, not a forecast.

Source: <https://www.bcg.com/press/30september2025-ai-leaders-outpace-laggards-revenue-growth-cost-savings>

- **Bain & Company** ("For Marketers, Generative AI Moves from Novelty to Necessity," 2024):

"Campaign time to market reduced by up to 50%, content creation time dropped by 30% to 50%, and hyper-personalized campaigns have boosted click-through rates by up to 40%."

Three numbers an agency CEO can put directly on a client proposal.

Source: <https://www.bain.com/insights/for-marketers-generative-ai-moves-from-novelty-to-necessity/>

- **Bain & Company** ("AI raises the stakes in marketing," 2025):

Leading companies are achieving "median revenue growth six times higher than competitors, while their average marketing spending is just 1.5 times higher — implying a four-times-higher marketing return on investment."

Source: <https://www.bain.com/about/media-center/press-releases/20252/ai-raises-the-stakes-in-marketing-opening-gap-between-leaders-and-laggards-in-the-race-to-harness-its-potentialbain--company-analysis/>

- **Gartner** ("2025 CMO Spend Survey," May 2025):

"22% of CMOs said GenAI has enabled them to reduce their reliance on external agencies for creativity and strategy building."

And: "39% of CMOs seek to reduce spending on labor." The threat agencies need a counter-narrative for.

Source: <https://www.gartner.com/en/newsroom/press-releases/2025-05-12-gartner-2025-cmo-spend-survey-reveals-marketing-budgets-have-flatlined-at-seven-percent-of-overall-company-revenue>

- **Gartner CMO survey** (November 2024):

"65% of CMOs say advances in AI will dramatically change their role in the next two years."

Source: <https://www.gartner.com/en/newsroom/press-releases/2024-11-17-gartner-survey-finds-65-percent-of-cmos-say-advances-in-ai-will-dramatically-change-their-role-in-the-next-two-years>

- **Salesforce** ("State of Marketing," 9th edition, 2024):

"75% of marketers are either experimenting with or have fully implemented AI" — 32% fully implemented, 43% experimenting.

Source: <https://www.salesforce.com/news/stories/marketing-trends-ai-data/>

- **Forrester** ("Predictions 2026: Marketing Agencies Resign Their Agency," October 2025):

"Agencies will no longer act solely as your agents but also as owners of solutions, resellers of technology partnerships, and developers of emerging capabilities."

Forrester also forecasts a **15% reduction in agency roles in 2026** and principal media reaching **~33% of total agency billings**. The single best one-line setup for *"white-label the platform now or be the platform's customer later."*

Source: <https://www.forrester.com/blogs/predictions-2026-marketing-agencies-resign-their-agency/>

Bucket 3 — Pressure quotes (client demand, urgency)

- **Mark Read, then-CEO, WPP** (Semafor, February 2025):

"At the start of the year [2024], client RFPs barely mentioned AI. That's starting to change... clients are looking for partners with strong capabilities and platforms powered by AI."

Anchor for the *"your clients are about to ask for this in the next RFP"* slide.

Source: <https://www.semafor.com/article/02/13/2025/how-ai-drives-mark-reads-year-of-execution-at-wpp>

- **CMO Barometer 2026, Serviceplan / House of Communication** (November 2025):

"Only 12% of CMOs expect agencies to lead on AI-specific skills."

Surveyed 805 marketing decision-makers across 15 countries. Translation for resellers: if you're not the AI provider, you're the one being disintermediated.

Source: <https://www.house-of-communication.com/it/en/newsroom/2025/11/cmo-barometer-2026.html>

- **CMO Barometer 2026** (November 2025):

"AI is the dominant focus for 2026, cited by 68% of respondents."

The urgency line for the cover slide.

Source: <https://www.house-of-communication.com/it/en/newsroom/2025/11/cmo-barometer-2026.html>

- **Gartner Marketing Survey** (February 2025):

"Over a quarter of marketing organizations have limited or no adoption of GenAI for marketing campaigns."

The gap an agency reselling an agent platform fills directly.

Source: <https://www.gartner.com/en/newsroom/press-releases/2025-02-18-gartner-survey-reveals-over-a-quarter-of-marketing-organizations-have-limited-or-no-adoption-of-genai-for-marketing-campaigns>

- **ANA In-House Agency Survey** (ANA via Marketing Dive, 2023; updated at ANA 2025):

"78% of marketers are working with some type of in-house agency" — up from 58% (2013) and 42% (2008).

Clients are insourcing. Agencies that resell a platform sit on the right side of that trend.

Source: <https://www.marketingdive.com/news/ana-in-house-agencies-rapidly-proliferate-and-theyre-handling-more-impor/539684/>

- **ANA** (December 2025):

Selected "Agentic AI" as 2025 Marketing Word of the Year.

Useful one-line proof that "*agent*" is now client-side vocabulary, not vendor jargon.

Source: <https://www.ana.net/content/show/id/pr-2025-12-word-year>

Bucket 4 — Incumbent & competitor moves (FOMO)

- **Mark Read, then-CEO, WPP** (Marketing Dive, 2024 / creative.salon, Cannes 2025):

"We can see [AI's] potential to make our people more productive, to produce more work at higher quality and lower cost, and to make our work more effective by delivering campaigns that are more targeted and relevant to consumers, and drive higher ROI to our clients."

WPP tech investment ~\$300M/yr (~2% of revenue); 50,000 employees/month using WPP Open.

Source: <https://www.semafor.com/article/02/13/2025/how-ai-drives-mark-reads-year-of-execution-at-wpp> · <https://creative.salon/articles/features/mark-read-q-a-ai-cannes-lions-2025>

- **Arthur Sadoun, CEO, Publicis Groupe** (The Drum, January 2024):

"In the age of AI, the name of the game is connect or die."

Publicis committed €300M over three years to its CoreAI platform.

Source: <https://www.thedrum.com/news/2024/01/25/do-things-tomorrow-no-one-can-do-today-inside-publicis-groupe-s-300m-bet-ai>

- **Arthur Sadoun, CEO, Publicis Groupe** (creative.salon, Cannes 2025):

"We have to put AI to work on real solutions to increase clients' market share."

Adweek headline phrasing also framed the moment as "*the ad industry's Kodak moment*" it must avoid.

Source: <https://creative.salon/articles/features/arthur-sadoun-cannes-2025-artificial-intelligence-publicis-groupe> · <https://www.adweek.com/agencies/arthur-sadoun-says-ai-shift-doesnt-need-to-be-ad-industrys-kodak-moment/>

- **John Wren, CEO, Omnicom** (Fortune, March 2025):

"Without the merger, both Omnicom and IPG would have to make similar investments in AI separately, building parallel platforms. But together, we can focus on a single

platform and a unified set of tools, democratizing them for our 120,000 employees."

The Omnicom–IPG merger is now openly described as an "AI test case."

Source: <https://fortune.com/article/omnicom-fortune-500-ceo-john-wren-interview-ipg-acquisition/>

- **John Wren, CEO, Omnicom** (The Drum, 2024):

Omnicom plans **~\$1B in labor cost cuts** as AI lands on agency P&Ls; *"talent will be the differentiator."*

Source: <https://www.thedrum.com/news/omnicom-says-talent-will-be-the-differentiator-as-it-plans-1bn-in-labor-cuts>

- **Yannick Bolloré, Chairman/CEO, Havas** (creative.salon, Cannes Lions 2025):

"AI is transforming from a tool into a strategic partner. We're now using AI to surface insights, forecast cultural shifts, and optimize media strategies. Through Converged, we connect content, data, and decision-making in one intelligent system."

Source: <https://creative.salon/articles/features/yannick-bollore-havas-ai-ceo-cannes-lions-series-ai>

- **Yannick Bolloré, Havas** (DecisionMarketing, 2025):

"Innovation happens where empathic human understanding meets machine precision... with artificial intelligence embedded at the core of everything we do."

Source: <https://www.decisionmarketing.co.uk/news/yannick-bollore-ai-embedded-at-the-core-of-all-we-do>

- **Hiroshi Igarashi, Global CEO, Dentsu** (creative.salon, Cannes Lions 2025):

"AI is accelerating our ability to reach some answers faster, but delivering true impact for our clients takes a more considered approach. We won't use it just because we can; it must also allow us to exceed client expectations."

Source: <https://creative.salon/articles/features/dentsu-ceo-hiroshi-igarashi-q-a-2025-cannes-lions>

- **Marc Benioff, CEO, Salesforce** (Agentforce 2.0 launch, December 2024 / Motley Fool, March 2025):

"When we're talking about agents, we're talking about digital labor... It is the 3 to 12 trillion dollar global shift where we are going to see digital labor takeover."

Salesforce's stated mission: *"to become the No. 1 digital labor provider, period."*

Source: <https://www.fool.com/data-news/2025/03/14/benioff-digital-labor-creating-12t-opportunity/> · <https://www.salesforceben.com/what-is-marc-benioffs-digital-labor-movement/>

- **Marc Benioff, CEO, Salesforce** (SF Standard, February 2025):

Salesforce will hire **no software engineers in 2025** because of AI productivity gains.

The most-quoted operator data point of the year for *"AI changes the shape of a services business."*

Source: <https://sfstandard.com/2025/02/27/salesforce-marcbenioff-layoffs-tech-agents/>

- **Jensen Huang, CEO, NVIDIA** (CES 2025 keynote, January 2025):

"The age of AI agentics is here... AI agents are the new digital workforce... a multi-trillion-dollar opportunity."

And: *"The IT department of every company is going to be the HR department of AI agents in the future."*

Source: <https://fortune.com/2025/01/06/nvidias-jensen-huang-agentics-ai-robots-blackwell-gpu-ces-2025-toyota-autonomous-vehicles/> · <https://fortune.com/2025/01/09/nvidia-ceo-jensen-huang-take-over-hr-ai-agents/>

- **Satya Nadella, CEO, Microsoft** (PYMNTS, May 2025):

Custom agents from Copilot Studio serve as his *"AI chiefs of staff."*

Microsoft framing: an *"open agentic web."* IDC data Microsoft cites: firms embedding AI agents with humans in the loop see **~3× greater returns** on AI investment than slower adopters.

Source: <https://www.pymnts.com/artificial-intelligence-2/2025/microsoft-ceo-satya-nadella-ai-agents-serve-as-chiefs-of-staff/>

Strongest combinations for the PDF

- **Threat slide:** Klarna 25% agency-spend cut · Gartner 22% of CMOs reducing agency reliance · Forrester 15% reduction in agency roles in 2026
- **FOMO slide:** WPP \$300M/yr · Publicis €300M · Omnicom \$1B cuts · Sadoun *"connect or die"*
- **TAM slide:** McKinsey \$4.4T (75% in 4 functions incl. marketing) · Bain *"campaigns 50% faster"* · BCG 30% productivity / *"double revenue growth"*
- **Incumbent-bet cluster:** Bolloré · Igarashi · Sadoun *"connect or die"* — even the giants are betting the company

Skipped intentionally

- Naval / Hassabis / da Vinci philosophical quotes — kept in the original bank above for tone slots only; not for conversion

- David Droga's "*grow into the future or shrink into the past*" — verifiable but undated in available sources; usable as flavour, not as operator hook